and some private/residential accommodations spread across nearby colonies in New Delhi.

When I joined the R&AW in February 1972, our office (establishment wing) was in a residential building in Green Park in New Delhi. Kao had by that time been promoted to secretary rank. This arrangement of offices scattered over multiple locations continued till early 1981, when the entire staff of the R&AW, including those sitting in South Block, shifted to a newly constructed building at the Central Government Offices complex off Lodhi Road. The South Block office space was handed over to the Ministry of Defence.

R.N. Kao's rank of secretary was personal to him. The rest of the officers carried IB/paramilitary forces ranks, such as director, joint director, deputy director, joint deputy director and assistant director. These ranks continued to be used till mid-1985, when pursuant to the formation of a separate dedicated cadre, for the R&AW, previous IB/paramilitary forces ranks were replaced by secretarial ranks, such as secretary, special secretary (with a secretary's pay), additional secretary, joint secretary, director, deputy secretary and undersecretary. G.C. (Gary) Saxena was the last R&AW chief to use the director rank, and he was the first secretary of the R&AW. My rank was also changed from that of deputy director to director. This is why readers might find two designations being used for the same person at different places in the book.

The Congress lost the sixth Lok Sabha elections in March 1977, resulting in the formation of Prime Minster Morarji Desai's four-party coalition government. Kao, who should have retired in May 1976 at the age of fifty-eight but was asked by Indira Gandhi to continue, finally put in his papers after the change in government. When K. Sankaran Nair took over from Kao, Morarji Desai reduced his rank from that of secretary to director because he suspected the R&AW to have been involved in Emergency-related activities. Nair opted for early retirement in protest. Desai also considerably reduced the department's budget, and consequently its strength, which seriously affected its performance for some time to come.

Nair's successor N.F. Suntook, was originally an emergency commissioned officer of the Indian Navy and later joined the Indian